Following One's Nose

Divrina Dhingra's *The Perfume Project* straddles genres—travelogue, history, science, memoir—all blending into an evocative whole

It happens to all of us. We're hurrying to cross a road or stepping into a shop to buy a pair of socks when—without the slightest warning—we're whisked away to another time and place. Neither by magic nor by teleportation technology, but by the whiff of frying jalebis or mosquito repellent or raw, splintery wood.

It is this magical power of the sense of smell—possibly the most evocative of our five senses—that Divrina Dhingra explores in *The Perfume Project*. The slim volume is written in a breezy and engaging manner and approaches its subject from various directions. It is an amusing travelogue; a detailed account of the perfume industry in India; an examination of the science of aromatics; and—perhaps most fascinatingly—an attempt to understand why smells are so intertwined with our memories that "any one of them encountered unexpectedly could conjure up images of people or places with near-hallucinatory clarity".

Dhingra delves into numerous texts—from arcane Sanskrit stories and the *Kama Sutra* to the *Akbarnama*—to trace the important role that fragrances have played in India over the centuries. She crisscrosses the country and undertakes bone-rattling, pre-dawn expeditions to observe rose harvests, saffron fields and jasmine distillation in places as far afield as Kannauj, Pampore and Madurai. And, of course,

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she revisits her own past to locate the smells that, for her, are intertwined with the idea of home: "dirt shot through with incense, cumin, turmeric, damp soil, the honeyed smell of night-blooming jasmine growing wild…"

To travel alongside Dhingra is to view history and geography in terms of fragrances. We hear about the bathwater of long-ago princesses that was "mixed with sandalwood, usira and camphor". About Mitti Itr, the popular *itr* made in Kannauj (by distilling earthen *kulhads*) which tries to mimic the smell of rain on dry mud. About the horrifying fact that during his dark reign, the smuggler Veerappan poached over 10,000 tonnes of sandalwood and literally erased entire forests.

Along the way, we are admitted into the complex "scent library" that Dhingra carries in her head and learn that, for example, it is possible to distinguish between different species of jasmine. That while the sambac jasmine smells "sweetly floral with airy green notes at first, but then increasingly voluptuous", the *raat ki rani* "smells like it is drenched in honey" and the parijat has a distinctive sulphurous note.

While offering unexpected glimpses into the "imprecise, messily beautiful universe of people, lands and stories that make up Indian perfume", *The Perfume Project* compels readers to engage with their world through their noses. ■

–Shabnam Minwalla

THE PERFUME PROJECT
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By Divrina Dhingra
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